

Inside Trump and Epstein’s Long, Complicated Relationship

POLITICS DONALD TRUMP 



Davidoff Studios—Getty Images

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It’s been six years since sex offender Jeffrey Epstein died by suicide while incarcerated, but his crimes—and his relationship with President Donald Trump—continues to loom large.

New emails released by House Democrats have brought their relationship back into the spotlight, with the late financier allegedly stating that Trump knew “about the girls” and that one of his alleged victims “spent hours” at his house with the President.

During his campaign, Trump pledged to release Epstein’s so-called “list.” But ten months into his current term, his Administration’s efforts to do so have fallen short of many supporters’ expectations.

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was a fixture in Palm Beach,” Trump said in 2019 soon after Epstein was charged. “I had a falling out with him a long time ago. I don’t think I’ve spoken to him for 15 years. I wasn’t a fan.”

Here’s a timeline of Trump and Epstein’s relationship.

Late 1980s

Though it is not known when Epstein and Trump first met, Trump told [New York magazine](#) in 2002 that he had known Epstein for 15 years, which would date back to the late 1980s.

“I’ve known Jeff for fifteen years. Terrific guy,” the magazine reported Trump saying in a phone interview. “He’s a lot of fun to be with. It is even said that he likes beautiful women as much as I do, and many of them are on the younger side. No doubt about it — Jeffrey enjoys his social life.”

1992

[NBC archival footage from 1992](#) shows Trump and Epstein at Mar-a-Lago, chatting and pointing at women dancing. In the background is Epstein’s associate Ghislaine Maxwell, later convicted of conspiring with Epstein in sex trafficking and sentenced in 2022 to 20 years in prison.

That same year, Florida businessman George Houraney [told The New York Times](#) he organized a “calendar-girl” party for Trump and Epstein featuring 28 women. Houraney later accused Trump of groping his girlfriend and business partner Jill Harth during a business presentation. Harth filed a 1997 sexual-assault lawsuit that she later dropped after settling a separate case with Trump, [according to the AP](#). Trump did not comment on the reporting at the time.

1993-1997

[Flight logs](#) from Epstein’s private jet show Trump, then-wife Marla Maples, and their daughter Tiffany flying several times in the mid-1990s. Those records, released earlier this year by Attorney General Pam Bondi, had been public previously.

Bondi’s release also included Epstein’s “black book,” which had also previously been published. The book featured names of prominent people including Trump, former President Bill Clinton, and Andrew Mountbatten Windsor, formerly Prince Andrew.

As The New York Times [reported](#), inclusion in the book did not necessarily indicate personal or business ties.

2003

In September, the House Oversight Committee released pages from a birthday book compiled for Epstein’s 50th birthday. Among the entries was a lewd sketch and note allegedly signed by Trump that read, “Happy Birthday—and may every day be another wonderful secret.”

Read More: [Epstein’s Full ‘Birthday Book’ Has Been Released. Here’s What’s Inside](#)

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“I have said all along, the very clear President Trump did not draw the picture, and he did not sign it,” Leavitt [wrote on X](#) after the letters were released. “President Trump’s legal team will continue to aggressively pursue litigation.”

2004

Trump and Epstein are said to have fallen out in 2004 over a business deal related to an oceanfront property called the Maison de L’Amitié in Palm Beach, according to the [Washington Post](#), with Trump ultimately offering the higher bid. Joseph Luzinski, the bankruptcy trustee, told the *Post* that the two faced-off as “two very large Palm Beach egos going at it.”

A year later, Florida police [opened](#) a sex-crimes investigation into Epstein that led to his 2008 conviction on state prostitution charges after he negotiated a plea deal granting him federal immunity. His attorney at the time, Alex Acosta, later served as Trump’s Labor Secretary.

2011

On Nov. 12, The House Oversight Committee [released](#) email correspondence from Epstein spanning 2011, 2015, and 2019 as part of a 23,000-document review of materials from the Epstein estate.

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dog that hasn’t barked.” Maxwell replied, “I have been thinking about that...” Epstein also claimed that one of his victims, whose name was redacted, had spent “hours” with Trump at his home.

A White House [statement to TIME](#) identified the woman as the late Virginia Giuffre, saying she had “repeatedly stated that President Trump was not involved in any wrongdoing whatsoever and couldn’t have been friendlier to her in their limited interactions.”

2015

In a December 2015 [email exchange](#), author Michael Wolff told Epstein that CNN planned to ask Trump about their relationship. When Epstein asked how he should respond, Wolff advised that he “let him hang himself.” He added that if Trump denied any connection, Epstein could later use it “to generate a positive benefit for you, or, if it really looks like he could win, you could save him, generating a debt.”

That June, Trump [announced](#) his first presidential campaign, which he would go on to win the [following year](#). Wolff later chronicled Trump’s early presidency in his 2018 bestseller *Fire and Fury: Inside the Trump White House*. Wolff is now in a legal dispute with First Lady Melania Trump after she threatened a \$1 billion lawsuit over comments he made linking her to Epstein.

2017

After Epstein’s 2008 conviction, Trump sought to distance himself from the financier.

Trump has said the friendship ended after Epstein recruited young women who worked at Mar-a-Lago for his own use. “He took some of the people who worked for me,” Trump [told reporters](#) in July. “Once he did that, that was the end of him.”

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The most recent emails obtained by the House Oversight Committee date from January 2019, during Trump’s presidency. In one, Epstein allegedly wrote to Wolff referencing a redacted victim’s name and

the word “Mar-a-Lago.” The message continues: “Trump said he asked me to resign—never a member ever... of course he knew about the girls, as he asked Ghislaine to stop.”

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